Moreover, as with the media, the dominant influence of old networks continued in the sphere of civil society. Of course, even the former Communist regimes used to have what looked like a civil society from the outside: a number of organisations from sport clubs, consumers' watchdogs and beekeepers' associations to United Nations' clubs, arts councils, charity organisations and peace institutes. But local party members were always given the task of ensuring that the 'right' people chaired these societies, and the state was only generous in financing them as long as they were giving value for money, i.e. providing the illusion of an independent civil society. During the political transition, some of these organisations proved to be extremely useful as shelters for discredited former Communists. Another useful new role of these organisations has been to produce all sorts of 'independent' and 'expert' opinions and reports to be used as political ammunition by the ex-Communists against their political adversaries, providing a veneer of competent professionalism for decisions which have been made for purely political or private interest reasons. In addition, civil society organisations have been often established from above, assisted by the EU, rarely emerging from the grassroots. Thus backed by international institutions, often blindly, the left has re-emerged as the dominant force in civil society too.

On the other hand, little valuable 'infrastructure' of civil society was already in place for the new political elite to use. As a result, the presence of new conservative political forces was limited to politics, where – lacking political experience – they often appeared coarse, clumsy, off-the-mark, professionally incompetent and with no real support in civil society. Usually, the only organisation that the conservative politicians could occasionally count on was the Church, but even here the local situation varied greatly across Eastern Europe. In devout Poland, the Church was an important player and waved the flag for change. In the more secular Czech Republic, it was rather marginal. In Croatia, it was strongly on the side of the main new nationalist political party. Generally speaking, without the Church's support, there would not have been enough votes to elect the new political elites in Central Europe at the time of key changes. This was certainly true in countries with a strong Catholic tradition, where the Church was not only the biggest single victim of the former regime but also its firmest opponent, nurturing a deep ideological/philosophical opposition